

The Tantra Called 'Obtained As It Is, Equal to Space'

Yathālabdha-kha-samatantra-nāma · Toh 441 · Derge Kangyur

ཇི་ཞིན་ལྷེ་པ་ནམ་མཁའ་དང་མཉམ་པ་ཞེས་བརྒྱུད་རིན་པོ་ལུ་

The Tantra Called "Obtained As It Is, Equal to Space," known in Sanskrit as the Yathālabdha-kha-samatantra and in Tibetan as Ji Zhin Nyepa Namkha Dang Nyampa, is a tantric text belonging to the Kangyur as Toh 441. It is a Buddhist tantra centered on the nature of mind and ultimate reality, framed around the figure of Vajrasattva and invoking the five buddhas, Vajradhara, and other primordial buddha forms. The text explores the theme that the intrinsic nature of awakened mind is like space — beginningless, unproduced, and beyond conceptual elaboration — and that genuine meditation on the ultimate cannot be reduced to mere mental purification. It opens with a verse homage to Vajrasattva and proceeds in a doctrinal and poetic register characteristic of the higher tantric literature of the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Yathālabdha-kha-samatantra-nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Tantra Called "Obtained As It Is, Equal to Space."

Homage to the Blessed One Vajrasattva (Skt. vajrasattva).

He who wears the crown of the five buddhas,
possesses the essence of all three grounds,
and manifests the identity of the glorious primordial buddha —
he acts in a manner equal to space.

If the mind is purified into such a nature as that,
this childish one would be meditating on the ultimate.
Yet the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is not thereby seen —
the buddhas, Vajradhara (the Vajra-holder), Ratnaketu (the Jewel-Pinnacle),
and Padmaja (the Lotus-Born) —
the intrinsic nature of these deities does not exist as such.
The primordial buddha is of the nature of space.
From the primordial Dharma those arise,
and together with space, the realms of sentient beings too
have been established as the authoritative treatise in the scriptures.
From the very beginning, the purity of the ground is equal to space.
Adorned again with the crown of the five buddhas,

whoever possesses the intrinsic nature of that very Dharma —
from them the Dharma of the three grounds arises.

To Vajrasattva I bow.

From bowing to Vajrasattva,
boundless merit likewise arises,
and by bowing to that Vajrasattva,
one will attain the great self of Dharma.

To fully contemplate all sentient beings as well —
this activity is of the nature of liberation.

All phenomena purified into Vajrasattva:
liberation is an activity of the nature of Dharma.

This Dharma is of a nature without destruction,
yet worldly people have made its nature into something else.

This — the body, speech, and mind —
is the first arising of this Dharma.

The abode of yoga is the instigating goddess;
from her, all phenomena first arise.

There, the mantras are to be cultivated as the single vajra entity.
The nature of Dharma is the vajra entity that is to be visualized,
adorned with the splendid crown of matted locks,
and the body's color is of a blue nature.

The virtue of Vajrasattva's meditative absorption —
the nature of unity itself is to be cultivated.

One should visualize abiding at the center of the solar maṇḍala,
and there contemplate the arising of the syllable itself.

From the fully transformed form of the syllable,
one should contemplate the very nature of vajra.

The edges of the lips are to be cultivated by the mantra-holder.
Through the very essence of one's own nature —
possessing the nature of the non-dual body —
Vajrasattva is to be visualized.

This is the mind itself fully accomplished,
as spoken by Vajradhara.

Whoever practices meditation through this very meditation
will realize the very nature of mind.

This is the single taste of the four goddesses.
Contemplate the essence with the mind as equal to space.
Making Dharma thus, the very nature of mind —
contemplate the goddesses as of the very nature of liberation.

What Vajrasattva sees
is of the nature of all phenomena.
The abode of yoga and its display —
together with the queens of universal equality —
abides possessed of its arrangements.
To one who is skilled, from the entity arises that which,
when Vajrasattva is seen,
the apprehended object of buddhas gathers and dissolves.

The four goddesses of fourfold nature
abide assuredly at the center.
With a nature like illusion
they pervade the three grounds.

In that divine place, the assembly of deities of the four faces
are themselves vajra.
There, all emanations of the buddhas
are of this very kind.

In just whatever manner sentient beings take birth,
in that very way
the emanations of the buddhas
become the manifold vajra.
All gods arising from that
are the emanations of Vajrasattva.

Regard sentient beings as the very essence of Dharma.
All three grounds are of a single essential nature.

The buddhas behold the one who performs the play,
and thereby all the sovereigns of yoga see her.
This is the first chapter: the chapter on the sacred commitments (samaya) of
the gods.

Always supreme, your own
sacred commitment goddesses — all of them —
the goddess who has become supreme among all goddesses:

we, the many, wish to make request of you.

To her, four songs are sung.

The one who is self-appearing, equal in Dharma, made inseparable from what is above;

the one who grants peace and liberation, who makes all equal with the supreme;

because through illusory activity she is equal to the buddhas;

the play pervading all of space is without cessation.

Ru lu ru lu bhyo ru dha.

All phenomena equal to space play everywhere.

Their appearance is equal in Dharma, having the nature of illusion and echo.

The aspect that does not abide together is like a lute tuned to itself.

It has become equal to whatever appearance arises through action.

Whatever the appearance of phenomena equal to the sky,

there the vajra-activity is as if possessed of form.

In the vajra vehicle, pleasures of form and so forth —

inexhaustible and manifold bliss — are what it bestows, making all equal.

This mode of the manifold vajra, the abode of yoga:

in grasping manifold form, one is equal to the vajra,

and the bodhisattvas who are like oneself rejoice.

Together with the vajra space, the supreme is bestowed.

The arousing of one's own self, equal to space, abiding there:

whoever listens to this with one-pointed mind

and holds this mind-song together with its words —

this song is equal to the sky.

There, in order to receive the vajra possessed of form,

the mind of vajra nature is awakened,

and because the nature is one, the tantra too is received.

This is the vajra word — the vajra, the other's nature.

The mantra-holder, having taken it into mind, contemplates all the maṇḍalas,

and meditates on that supreme lotus abiding at the center of the Dharma maṇḍala.

The phenomenon abiding at the center of the maṇḍala has the quality of hūṃ.

All forms are to be ascertained definitively as being of the nature of illusion.

Contemplate the single essence of mind: it is the vajra vehicle.

Mind is equal to space; the mind vehicle is without intrinsic nature.

The nature of both is likewise not embodied.

There, by virtue of the absence in the vajra,

Vajrasattva, you are of a single nature.

For those of the world, you manifest in the very nature of illusion,

and you awaken sentient beings in the nature that tames them.

O Vajrasattva, you are a single reality.

The four goddesses declare: the vajra is thoroughly relinquished throughout.

That which abides within possesses vajra-play,

and by the very essence of mind it fully abides there.

The secret Dharma of mind emerges from that.

The vajra, possessed of the nature of space, is to be expanded,

and the expanded vajra is again gathered in,

for it is one with the nature of mind.

When mind comes to cessation,

all is seen as equal and alike.

By gathering the mantra again and again,

the action of unity is performed.

This is the second chapter: the chapter on the maṇḍala of mind.

The brahmin and the outcaste are of a single nature:

the Buddha has declared this to be the nature of all phenomena.

The thing that abides in the nature of the one

is declared by the vajra-holder to be of equal essence.

Brahmin and dog are indeed a single reality,

and bone ornaments too are of the nature of illusion —

that is the nature of one who receives the rank of the vajra.

The yogin sees that with equal essence,

and the nature equal to that is concealed within sentient beings.

The nature of that yoga is declared by the goddess:

All goddesses are there in a single nature.

You, the sole beautiful one, arise together with the principal.

That equal nature belongs to the mantra-holder alone:

it is the single one who fully awakens the vajra.

There, the natures of aversion are dissolved,

and the Dharma of the severed limb comes to arise.

There, in a single nature, is the vajra lady.

When one praises the vajra with melody,

look upon the left half of the god as having merged into one.

Taking scripture itself as valid cognition, meditate on that Vajrasattva.

This is the third chapter, the chapter on the maṇḍala of speech.

Elephant and horse and human and dog and ox —

all of these, without exception, having fully become what they are:

those very samaya substances are in nature identical as one.

The yogin consumes them with a nature equal to the sky.

This samaya was spoken by the four goddesses.

Being endowed with a mind intent on meditation, the yogin,

through the single-pointed mind, will accomplish Vajradhara himself.

The mind that comes with actual substance will arise.

The peaceful essence of the vajra's enactment has not been stated plainly —

therefore one should realize all phenomena as equality,

and analyze them in that way as equal to the sky.

This god, Vairocana, and the five goddesses are his very identity.

In the vajra vehicle, the nature is that of equality.

Because the one who impels is the nature of conditioned existence,

the single foremost, Vajrasattva, is seen in the form of the body.

For those who aspire to the vajra vehicle, the goddesses speak thus.

This generation of truth is spoken by the goddess Vairocana.

This, dwelling in the center of the moon, is the meditation: it is the secret mantra of the vajra.

That is meditating on the vajra with single-pointed mind —

the vajra blazing brightly, with its three prongs.

Meditate on the nature of the vajra dwelling in the center of the yogin's abode.

I have taught in the vajra vehicle in this way:

the nature of all phenomena as being identical as one.

This is the fourth chapter, the chapter on the maṇḍala of the body.

From the impermanent and without substance, one does not meditate on a body with substance.

It is the actual substance that the goddess impels.

Thus one must investigate exactly from the Dharma.

Mind has the defining mark of being like the sky,
and the actual substance is to be made into a substance without vehicle.
In the intrinsic nature of substance there is no vehicle.
Mind has a nature equal to the sky itself.
The mind is to be engaged exactly as before.
How then is this to be made into substance?
This substance will not be accomplished as a vehicle.
Sentient beings have the defining mark of being like the sky.
In the center, the word is to be examined precisely within the Dharma,
and from mind it is to be made into actual substance.
Through the nature of the mode of manifold aspects,
Vajrasattva is to be generated.
Just as water that is clear and unmixed with turbidity —
a mind of that kind is to be accomplished as the essence of swiftness.
Thus I have taught what is otherwise unteachable.
Through the nature of the body of Vajrasattva,
it is to be made into the identity of the fourth aspect.
In that, the vajra water has the nature of the chosen deity,
and the yogin is to consume it as the identity of mind.
Dharma and Saṅgha and vajra water — all of these are equal in nature.
Bile and blood and the rest, supremely beautiful in their dwelling, the body of
substance is to be transformed.
Food and drink and bedding and so forth — all of those are of this nature.
Whatever is taught with certainty as samādhi is also of that same identical
nature.
The buddha has made all three entirely into the nature of the vajra.
All phenomena have the nature of being without substance,
and the vajra-holder has declared them to be of the nature of illusion.
The nature of that appears individually as equal to the sky.
Through the definitive teaching that it is of the nature of illusion,
one is to enter with certainty into the vajra.
In the intrinsic nature of sentient beings there is no vehicle.
Mind is the essential heart dwelling within that.
Of such a nature, as the very identity of mind,
you, the mantra-holder, will accomplish it.

Expansion, contraction, and gathering once more — all three together are of a single, identical nature. Mind is made equal to Mount Meru and to Hūṃ, and mind is again aroused as the pure buddha. When mind becomes weary, the gathering takes place once more. At that point, the mantra-holder is to examine and cultivate it. Through the act of gathering, one is to engage again. Vajrasattva (Skt. Vajrasattva) moves the body there. Once again, through the nature of the sky, by means of the wrathful, it is thus the nature of expansion and contraction.

For Vajrasattva to accomplish a single siddhi (Skt. siddhi), it is therefore fitting that expansion too belongs to the vajra-holder. When the mantra-holder has become stable, expand. If stability has not been attained, to expand here would not draw the fruit of the body's afflictions. The essential matter of the vehicle — that all things are true — these have been taught. The meditation on Dharma of that kind has the essential nature of the vajra.

Mind equal to the sky is not to be despised; it is not defiled by any stain whatsoever.

O yogin! The Blessed One's Mother, the inciting consort, is of primordial nature. Through meditating on the arising of the vajra, she brings about the arising of buddhas. The goddesses are of a single nature with the gods, and Vajrasattva brings about the arising of the accomplished buddhas. Through the mind of meditation held with sustained attention, that too is accomplished by the syllable Hūṃ. The delusion of conceptual thought in the thighs and legs is not to be held in mind.

This very wheel of the three worlds is perfectly bound by the rays of the vajra. The mantra-holder is to expand the wrathful deity into the realm of the sky — ten thousand million times — and then, into the vajra that has become of one single nature, one is to definitively gather them back once more.

The vehicle of awakening is the intrinsic nature of mind, and awakening too is the intrinsic nature of mind. Both together constitute the vehicle of the nature of mind, and mind itself is of a nature equal to the sky.

This is the fifth chapter, which is shared in common with other tantras.

The tantra entitled "Equal to the Sky, Obtained as It Is" is complete.

Translated, revised, and definitively established by the great Indian paṇḍita Tākṣaka Gaṇa and the Tibetan translator, the fully ordained monk Bodhiprajñā of Mang'or.

Translator's Notes

- The title Yathālabdha-kha-samatantra-nāma is a reconstructed Sanskrit title as given in the colophon preamble. The Tibetan rendering "Obtained As It Is, Equal to Space" follows the text's own Tibetan gloss.

The names Ratnaketu and Padmaja rendered in Sanskrit are educated reconstructions of the Tibetan ར་རྩ་ཆེ་བའི་འཇམ་མཁའ་མཆོག་ (literally "jewel-pinnacle," corresponding to the well-attested buddha name Ratnaketu) and འཇམ་མཁའ་འཇུག་པའི་འཇམ་མཁའ་མཆོག་ (literally "one who is lotus-adorned entering," less standard; "Padmaja" is approximate). These names appear in the context of the five-buddha family and Vajradhara, though the exact grouping here is unusual.

The phrase rendered "the great self of Dharma" (महामहार्मात्मनः) corresponds to Sanskrit mahādharmatman or mahātmadharmā; this is a tantric term signifying the vast, non-personal Dharma-identity, not a substantial self, and the translation preserves the technical flavor intentionally.

The line 經傳之於經 is syntactically compressed and somewhat ambiguous; the rendering "established as the authoritative treatise in the scriptures" is a plausible reading but the precise referent of "the scriptures" is not entirely clear from context.

- The syllables "Ru lu rü lu bhyo ru dha" are a mantra string rendered phonetically in the Tibetan and are left untranslated as is standard practice for dhāraṇī and mantra sequences.

The phrase rendered "the one who does not abide together is like a lute tuned to itself" is a difficult simile. The Tibetan pi wang, a lute or vīṇā-like instrument, is used to illustrate self-resonance or self-nature; the line concerns phenomena that neither fully co-exist nor fully separate, analogous to the self-sounding strings of an instrument. This reading is plausible but the verse is compressed and the precise doctrinal referent is uncertain.

The closing phrase "the Dharma of the severed limb" likely refers to a tantric transgressive or antinomian practice associated with the Kāpālika or Śaiva contexts being deliberately subverted here, or to the dissolution of conceptual distinctions symbolized by such imagery. Its precise meaning in this tantric context is not fully determinable without access to a root commentary.

- The samaya substances listed — elephant, horse, human, dog, and ox flesh — are the standard pentad of transgressive or "secret" samaya substances in certain Vajrayāna ritual contexts. The passage assumes this technical background without spelling it out.

The phrase rendered "the one who impels is the nature of conditioned existence" is dense and the syntax is compressed; it appears to identify the impelling goddess with saṃsāric existence as a pedagogical contrast or as an esoteric identification. The precise doctrinal logic is not fully transparent from the verse alone.

The "fourth aspect" near the end likely refers to a fourfold division of the body's maṇḍala discussed in the surrounding tantra; without the larger commentary the precise referent remains uncertain.

- The phrase rendered "the Blessed One's Mother, the inciting consort" (ཀློང་གི་མཆོད་སྐྱོར་ལྷ་མོ།) refers in tantric context to the female consort or wisdom-consort who, as the "Mother of the Blessed One," embodies the Perfection of Wisdom; རྒྱུ་བྱ་ལྷ་མོ། specifically means "she who incites or stirs," a technical epithet for an activating consort figure.

The phrase "mind is made equal to Mount Meru and to Hūṃ" reflects a tantric visualization in which mind, Mount Meru, and the seed-syllable Hūṃ are equated in size or scope; the precise

syntactic relationship is compressed in the original.

The expression "the fruit of the body's afflictions" (ལྷན་པོའི་སྐྱོན་འབྲས་ཀྱི་ཕན་ལོ་ལྷན་པོའི་སྐྱོན་འབྲས་ཀྱི་ཕན་ལོ་) is notably terse; it may mean that without stability, the expansion practice will fail to extract or purify the karmic results lodged in the body's afflictions.

The colophon names the Indian paṇḍita as Tākṣaka Gaṇa; this name is otherwise unattested in the standard translation colophon lists and may be a variant reading.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.